

Partaking of communion in good order.

Please note these directives about requirements for anyone to be allowed to have communion. We live in an age when people in the world feel entitled to everything, but we are Christians, and we are not of the world, and we should not feel entitled to have Holy Communion regardless of how we act and live. We are given communion by the grace of God and because we have prepared as best we can. The angels long to have the things that God gives us freely, but not cheaply.

Preparation for holy Communion is an ongoing process, day by day. It is not just coming to the church, having communion, and then leaving. Some of that is happening in our church, and it must stop, because if we do not respect communion, we are a scandal to the angels, a distraction and temptation to our brothers and sisters, and it is possible even for us to be sick physically and spiritually, as the apostle Paul teaches us.

If you wish to have communion Sunday, you should be fasting to the best of your abilities. If you ignore fasting completely, you should not commune. If you do not fast strictly according to the church's typicon, you may commune, but only if you have a blessing from Fr. Nicholas or Fr. Seraphim. We have blessed many people to moderate their fasting. We don't do anything in the church by ourselves. We do things in obedience.

You should also have said the "Preparation Prayers for Communion." They can be said the night before, or the day of holy Communion, or even in segments, for instance, the morning before, the night before, and in the morning of Liturgy. If you do not know what these prayers are, you should talk to one of us.

Preparation also includes coming to the evening service before Liturgy. If you do not come to the evening service, you must have a blessing from Fr.

Nicholas or Fr. Seraphim. We are very free in giving blessings, and when we do, we ask you to say some short additional prayers.

You should go to confession regularly and have had a recent confession, according to the blessing of Fr. Seraphim or Fr. Nicholas, before communion.

Of course, you should be on time to the Divine Liturgy. If you plan to come late for liturgy or habitually come late to liturgy, you should not commune. If you are late because of exigent circumstances, and you have at least heard the Gospel and the Epistle, you may commune, but not if this is a regular occurrence. As in all things, if Fr. Nicholas or Fr. Seraphim give you a blessing to be late, you may commune.

There is not always good order in our church after communion. We have become aware that there is a lot of talking, and people taking out cell phones and showing pictures and such. This is a scandal before angels, God, and our brothers and sisters around us. It is a sin, and as a rector who loves you, I forbid it.

I also have become aware that sometimes people take communion and then march right out of the church or start talking and relaxing as if they're leaving a movie theater. This is a sin. If you intend to leave the church before the end of the service, do not take communion. This would include going on in the deck to chat and visit. Please remember that Judas took Holy Communion at the Last Supper, and then he left early to go betray the Lord. The church remembers this, and many fathers have likened leaving church early without good cause to acting like Judas.

There is always a risk when a pastor tells people anything that they should do that they judge him and the church, saying that this is just a bunch of rules. We are not telling you mere rules because Fr. Nicholas or Fr. Seraphim want to control your lives; we are teaching you the way of life. We must be orderly when

we worship, and we must think about our brothers and sisters standing in our midst, and we must respect that in the Divine liturgy we partake of the body and blood of Jesus Christ, which is a fire that burns the unworthy but warms and enlightens the faithful.

In summary, please observe the following ways of life regarding Holy Communion:

- Observe fasting according to the blessing of father Nicholas or Fr. Seraphim
- Have a recent confession.
- Come to the evening service, or have a blessing from Fr. Nicholas or Fr. Seraphim.
- Say the preparation prayers for holy Communion.
- Be on time for liturgy.
- If you plan to leave the service after communion and not wait till the end, you should not commune.
- After communion, do not talk as if you are leaving the theater, and do not use your cell phone under any circumstances until the end of the service.

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